

THE CIVIL WAR IN POPULAR CULTURE



Memory and Meaning

EDITED BY LAWRENCE A. KREISER JR. AND RANDAL ALLRED

“Oh, I’m a Good Ol’ Rebel”

Reenactment, Racism, and the Lost Cause

Christopher Bates

Captain Vern Padgett is a Confederate Civil War reenactor—a member of the Richmond Howitzers. Though a California native, he is one of the more die-hard Confederate reenactors—not in terms of his devotion to an accurate impression but in his commitment to what he perceives as the southern cause. His e-mail messages often have titles like this: “Rebuttal to ravings of misinformed Yankee propagandists.” He thinks nothing of lecturing his fellow reenactors on the “facts the historians leave out,” with the goal of correcting what he calls “Northern platitudes.”¹

Padgett is best known—both inside and outside reenactment circles—for his advocacy of the notion that the Confederate army included significant numbers of African American soldiers.² The fact that academic historians categorically reject—and even deride—this idea only encourages Padgett. He has a lengthy and highly polished lecture on the subject that he has delivered at dozens of Civil War roundtables and other Civil War–related gatherings. His presentation makes use of all the hard evidence he has been able to gather—a few photographs, a handful of quotations and diary excerpts, and several other odds and ends. The centerpiece of his argument, however, is creative mathematics. Working backward from a single piece of information—that a dozen African Americans qualified for veterans’ pensions in Tennessee in 1905—he “calculates” how many black soldiers actually served in the Confederate army. By his figuring, Tennessee had about 10 percent of the South’s population in 1905, so those 12 pensioners actually represent 120 soldiers if

extrapolated across the entire South. Next, he calculates that because only 20 percent of Civil War soldiers lived until 1905, those 120 survivors represent 600 soldiers. Padgett continues through several more iterations using this mathematical sleight of hand and ultimately concludes that the Confederate army had as many as 200,000 black soldiers. This is a staggering number, given that, at its height, the entire Confederate army numbered perhaps 1 million soldiers. When pressed to explain why a group that—in his analysis—constituted as much as 15 or 20 percent of the Confederate army has left so little evidence of its existence behind, Padgett falls back on the other main theme of his lecture: that professional historians can't be trusted and are inclined to hide information that doesn't fit their preconceived notions.³

Don Worth is also a Confederate reenactor—primarily as a member of the Third Georgia. "I am an absolute nut about the Civil War," he explains. "I have no idea why."⁴ Worth, a retired computer systems administrator, has been reenacting for nearly two decades. His interest in the Civil War dates back much further, however, to when he was a youngster during the Civil War centennial of 1961 to 1965. He explains how he was first drawn to the Civil War:

My grandfather gave me the *Life* magazines in the early 1960s and the *American Heritage Book of the Civil War*. I had to do a Civil War project for school—sixth grade?—and I remember cutting out pictures from the magazines for the report and looking up what I then considered obscure generals in the encyclopedia. At the same time, because of the centennial there were lots of other Civil War-related things around. For example, I had the Marx Blue and Gray plastic soldiers play set. . . . *The Gray Ghost* was on TV and I had seen the movie *Friendly Persuasion* and loved it. One of my friends had the Avalon Hill Game *Gettysburg* and I had to get that too. I ended up buying their Chancellorsville game too. And I had stacks and stacks of the Whitman Confederate play money. When I visited Knott's Berry Farm, I bought replicas of *Harper's Weekly* from the Civil War era too.⁵

Worth believes that in the 1950s and 1960s, children's exposure to the past was more extensive than it is today. Toy stores, for example, were filled

with items inspired by historical events and individuals. Besides its Blue and Gray line, Marx sold toy soldiers from the Mexican-American War, the War of 1812, the Revolutionary War, and the Indian Wars. There were Red Ryder BB Guns, Lincoln Logs, Davy Crockett coonskin caps, and miniature Sherman tanks. History was also a mainstay of television programming. "Disney immersed us in every historical character he could lay his hands on—*Davy Crockett*, *Johnny Tremain*, *The Swamp Fox*," Worth remembers. Still, it was the Civil War that captured his heart:

I remember being very impressed with John Mosby—the main character of *The Gray Ghost* TV series. I remember being much more interested in the Confederates—those dashing cavaliers! I suspect I was mostly a product of my times—the centennial washed over all of us like a giant wave. Perhaps it was partly that we were living in the era of the Cold War—with the constant threat of annihilation, and it was pleasant to cast oneself back to an earlier, simpler time. . . . The stories that came from the war seemed full of passion and heroism and noble deeds. I couldn't get nearly as excited about the Revolutionary War—even with movies like *Johnny Tremain*—or other wars.⁶

As he entered young adulthood, Worth's passion for the Civil War waned. He attended college during the height of the antiwar movement; this was followed by marriage and the start of his career, and his attention was directed elsewhere. In the late 1980s, however, his interest reblossomed. He's not sure why, although he says some personal problems—and the desire to escape, on occasion—played a role. This time in his life coincided with a dramatic increase in attention to the Civil War, thanks in part to the movies *Glory* (1989) and *Gettysburg* (1993), as well as Ken Burns's PBS series *The Civil War* (1990). Today, the Civil War is once again a major part of Don Worth's life. Besides reenacting, he has created extensive Civil War-related websites, compiled a large collection of Gettysburg photographs, visited dozens of battlefields, taken courses on the war, and attended several Civil War conferences.

On those occasions when Padgett and Worth attend reenactments as Confederates, they find themselves with a lot of company. Roughly two-thirds of reenactors play Confederate soldiers or civilians as their primary roles. If those individuals who sometimes trade in northern blues for south-

ern grays—"galvanizers," in reenactor parlance—are included, then the percentage of reenactors who at least occasionally do southern impressions jumps to about 85 percent.⁷ In many places, the imbalance between the two sides is so overwhelming that new reenactors are required to portray Union soldiers for several months to a year, just to ensure that there are enough Federals to actually stage a battle. Although it may not be surprising that this is the case in the South, the imbalance between Union and Confederacy also exists beyond the Mason-Dixon line. Of the fifty states, only Massachusetts has more Union reenactors than Confederates, in large part due to the many African American units based there.⁸ Among the 10,000 or so individuals who participate in foreign Civil War reenactment groups—primarily in Australia, France, Germany, Italy, and the United Kingdom—the same imbalance exists.

These numbers—with Confederate outnumbering Federal reenactors by about 2 to 1—are essentially the inverse of the actual Civil War. During the war itself, the Union army comprised roughly 2.4 million men, which means it enjoyed a manpower advantage of about 2.5 to 1.⁹ This was primarily because states in the North and the West had far more people than those in the South. It was also due to the fact that—regardless of what Vern Padgett says—the Union government could draw on its working classes to build its army, whereas the South's 4 million slaves were largely unavailable to the Confederate army.¹⁰ These facts were true in the 1860s, and they remain true for Civil War reenactment today. That is, the states of the North and the West—not to mention the nations of Europe and Oceania—still have far more people than the South does. It is also the case that the reenacted Confederate army cannot draw on African Americans.¹¹ Thus, it is intriguing that the majority of reenactors are Confederates. The South did, after all, lose the war.

Most outsiders who have analyzed this conundrum have reached a fairly straightforward answer: southern racism. The presumption is that the reenactment community—or at least the Confederate segment of that community—is made up of backward-looking, ultraconservative, reactionary white southerners who are threatened by the changes that have taken place since the civil rights movement. The views of political scientist James O. Farmer are characteristic of this perspective. In a 2005 essay he concludes, "It is not surprising that the era of affirmative action has seen a corresponding growth in the reenactment hobby, for it offers both an escape from that world, however brief, and a symbolic defiance of it." Participation in reenactment offers "the

"tradition loving white Southerner" a chance to "send his message to the NAACP."¹²

A more careful analysis, however, makes it clear that this interpretation is a gross oversimplification at best and wholly inaccurate at worst. If one met Don Worth and Vern Padgett at a Civil War reenactment, it would be difficult to detect much of a difference between the two. However, as the preceding twin narratives make clear, there *is* a great deal of difference. Indeed, there is a broad spectrum of Confederate reenactment, with Worth at one end and Padgett at the other. And both ends of this spectrum are far better understood not as a product of modern-day racism but in the context of the southern "Lost Cause" interpretation of the Civil War—a blend of romance and politics that still has enormous resonance today. The perception of Confederate reenactors as backward-looking racists is primarily the result of factors beyond their control. Since the 1950s, *actual* backward-looking racists—the Ku Klux Klan, the League of the South, Dixie Republic, some neo-Nazi groups—have made extensive use of the Confederacy and its symbols, particularly the Confederate battle flag and the common soldier of the Confederate army. The South in general, and any person who utilizes or affiliates with these symbols in particular, has suffered by association. The average Confederate reenactor is hardly a tree-hugging, Prius-driving, ACLU card-carrying, left-wing radical, but even if he were, it would make little difference.

In the past half century, scholars of various stripes have taken a great deal of interest in the symbolic meaning of the South in American culture. That meaning has grown and evolved over time, such that the region now has many and varied significances—both positive and negative. "The South today," as historian Tara McPherson observes, "is as much a fiction, a story we tell and are told, as it is a fixed geographic space below the Mason-Dixon line."¹³ A full survey of this subject is beyond the scope of this essay; a brief overview must suffice.

The South's geography, economy, culture, and religious traditions have been distinctly different from those of the North for more than 400 years, but it was not until the 1850s that southern writers began to strive in earnest to articulate a distinctly southern identity. The novels of John Pendleton Kennedy, the poetry of William Grayson, and the scholarship of William Fitzhugh all sought to emphasize the positive qualities of the South (usually by contrasting them with the negative qualities of the industrial North). A number

of northerners aided their cause—among them Ohioan David Christy with his book *Cotton Is King* (1855), New York printmakers Nathaniel Currier and James Merritt Ives, and Pennsylvania composer Stephen Foster, responsible for the popular songs “My Old Kentucky Home,” “Oh! Susanna,” and “Old Folks at Home.”

During the Civil War and Reconstruction, the South took a literal and metaphorical beating, and it is from this context that the Lost Cause interpretation of the war emerged from the pens of writers such as Jubal Early, John Esten Cooke, Thomas Nelson Page, and Edward A. Pollard. The bedrock of the Lost Cause was romantic imagery—gentlemanly Robert E. Lee, daring Stonewall Jackson, magnolias and cotton fields, the idyllic life of the plantations. These appealing notions were the anchor for a series of ideas about the war—that the Confederacy never really had a chance of winning but almost did anyway, that the South’s purpose was to fight not for slavery but for states’ rights, and so forth. The purpose of the Lost Cause was twofold: to redeem the tarnished image of the South and make a case to northerners for the southern states’ full reinstatement into the Union (under white leadership), and to help the defeated Confederates come to grips with their loss of the war.¹⁴

The architects of the Lost Cause were remarkably successful in their task. The interpretation, not surprisingly, quickly gained traction among white southerners. Perhaps more important, it also gained wide acceptance among white northerners. Scholars Karen L. Cox, Nina Silber, and Robert Wiebe, among others, have observed that a South that symbolized an older, simpler America and a life of leisure, individualism, honor, and romance was very reassuring at a time when the world was modernizing, industrializing, and speeding up.¹⁵ Entrepreneurs in all parts of the country seized on this opportunity, creating what McPherson characterizes as a “vast nostalgia industry.”¹⁶ Southerners developed a bustling tourist industry, showcasing their region at a number of high-profile events, including the New Orleans Universal Exposition and World’s Fair of 1884, the Atlanta Cotton States and International Exposition of 1895, and the South Carolina Inter-State and West Indian Exposition of 1901. Northern novelists such as Owen Wister, John William DeForest, Frank R. Stockton, Sarah Orne Jewett, and Thomas Bailey Aldrich made frequent use of romantic southern settings and symbols, while *Harper’s Monthly*, *Atlantic Monthly*, *Cosmopolitan*, *Lippincott’s*, and *Munsey’s* regularly published extensive southern travelogues.

By the early decades of the twentieth century, as Gaines M. Foster has

observed, the Lost Cause had served its purposes—the South had been reintegrated into the United States, and the Civil War generation had either passed from the scene or coped with defeat.¹⁷ Nonetheless, the mythology of the Lost Cause remained salient and even continued to grow. Madison Avenue advertising agencies fashioned product names and mascots that referenced the antebellum South—Aunt Jemima, Uncle Ben, and Dixie cups.¹⁸ Tin Pan Alley composers, many of whom had never visited the region, produced tune after tune that celebrated southern heritage: “Swanee” (1919), “Carolina in the Morning” (1922), “Way Down Yonder in New Orleans” (1922), and “Sweet Georgia Brown” (1925).¹⁹ Filmmakers had a particularly profound impact, and the “Old South” genre was a Hollywood mainstay for many years. Examples include *The Fighting Coward* (1924), *The River of Romance* (1929), *Hearts in Dixie* (1929), *Mississippi* (1935), *So Red the Rose* (1935), *Way Down South* (1939), *Song of the South* (1946), *The Mississippi Gambler* (1953), *Band of Angels* (1957), and—most famously—*The Birth of a Nation* (1915) and *Gone with the Wind* (1939).²⁰ Historians, both within the academy and without, also played a role in sustaining a positive image of the South and of the Confederate war effort, among them Douglass Southall Freeman, Ulrich B. Phillips, Shelby Foote, and Bruce Catton.²¹

Though a generally favorable conception of the South and the Confederacy remained transcendent until the 1960s, the first signs of a negative counterimage began to appear in the 1920s. Southern writers—William Faulkner, Tennessee Williams, Lillian Hellman—set their novels in a South that had its charms but was deeply flawed.²² At the same time, news events—the resurgence of the Ku Klux Klan, labor violence, the Scopes trial of 1925, outbreaks of hookworm and pellagra, the Dust Bowl of the 1930s—had some scholars and observers speaking of a “benighted” South. This trend reached its apex in the 1950s and 1960s, as Americans across the nation watched peaceful civil rights protesters face off against white southerners, many of whom were very angry and violent. For the first time since Reconstruction, the South’s image among citizens outside the region was arguably more negative than positive. In particular, the symbols of the Confederacy—utilized extensively by opponents of the civil rights movement—took on connotations of racism and oppression that the Lost Cause interpretation had successfully countermanded for more than half a century.

The blow to the South’s image was immediately evident in newspapers. By 1951, the *Chicago Tribune* was editorializing against “Bigotry and

Ignorance in [the] Deep South.”²³ In 1956 the *Los Angeles Times* characterized southerners as “the prejudiced, the ignorant, and the arrogant.”²⁴ The next year, when nine black students attempted to enroll at Little Rock Central High School in Arkansas and were rebuffed by Governor Orval Faubus, the *Washington Post* spoke of the “nation’s disgust.”²⁵ In 1961 the *New York Times* lamented that New Orleans, previously known for its “spirit of tolerance,” had become a focal point for “racial hate.” Four years later the paper decried “a conspiracy against the law and for the suppression of Negroes.”²⁶ A 1957 poll conducted by George Gallup is particularly instructive: 74 percent of northerners said they would never consider living in the South; among the reasons they cited were the following:

Southerners are fine people, but they’re a little behind the times.
I think they’re kinda slow.
They’re fine, if they’d only stop fighting the Civil War.
They’re lazy, shiftless and ignorant.
They carry their racial prejudice too far.²⁷

Similarly, in a 1970 study northern college students were asked to pick the word they felt best described southerners. The most popular responses included three positive descriptors—friendly, hospitable, and polite—and ten negative ones—lazy, shiftless, unambitious, backward, ignorant, low class, uneducated, intolerant, bigoted, and segregationist.²⁸

The change in popular perceptions of the South also became apparent in the world of cinema. Although positive filmic portrayals of the region did not disappear after the 1960s—think *Coal Miner’s Daughter* (1980), *Driving Miss Daisy* (1989), *Steel Magnolias* (1989), and *Fried Green Tomatoes* (1991), as well as the television programs *The Golden Girls* (1985), *Designing Women* (1986), and *Evening Shade* (1990)—the “Old South” genre was dead.²⁹ Further, movies that used the South as a setting for plots centered on racism, ignorance, and other forms of deviance became quite common. Examples include *To Kill a Mockingbird* (1962), *In the Heat of the Night* (1967), *Easy Rider* (1969), *The Texas Chain Saw Massacre* (1974), *The Color Purple* (1985), and *Mississippi Burning* (1988). Perhaps the most memorable specimen of this genre is the 1972 film *Deliverance*, which follows four Atlanta businessmen on a camping trip through the rural South as they are terrorized and raped by a group of backwoods southerners.³⁰

Evolving attitudes about the South also resulted in a pair of notable rhetorical developments in American English. First, as sociologist John Shelton Reed has demonstrated, the term *Dixie*—which carries pleasing connotations of the moonlight and magnolias of the antebellum South—fell out of favor, supplanted by the more generic *South*.³¹ At the same time, there was a change in the meaning of the term *redneck*. In the nineteenth century, the term simply referred to poor, uneducated southerners who had to work in the fields and thus ended up with sunburned necks.³² It slowly grew more negative over time and then took a dramatic downward turn in the 1960s. By the end of that decade, rednecks were no longer just poor and stupid; they were also toothless, inbred, and racist. And they were no longer found only in rural areas; they lived all across the South.³³

The connection between the redneck stereotype and the Confederacy was evident in an April 1965 article in *Time* magazine entitled “The Various Shady Lives of the Ku Klux Klan.” It featured a picture of Ku Klux Klan imperial wizard Robert Shelton in front of a Confederate flag, along with this explanation: “No longer a monolithic organization, the Klan today consists of several ragtag independent groups, the best known of which is the United Klans of America, Knights of the Ku Klux Klan, Inc., headquartered in Tuscaloosa, Ala. with an ex-tire salesman named Robert Shelton as its Imperial Wizard. Estimates of Klan strength range from 10,000 to 40,000 members, many of whom for some peculiar reason seem to be rural service-station attendants. Most members, in any case, are deluded rednecks whose only skill is sharpshooting.”³⁴ The Confederate soldier cannot be separated from his flag or his nation, so when the Confederacy and its battle flag were appropriated and transformed by anti-civil rights activists, the Confederate soldier was taken along for the ride. Johnny Reb and the Confederate flag became the embodiment of defiance of the federal government, racism, and a host of other unflattering characteristics ascribed to southerners. As historian James C. Cobb observes, “[When] the Civil Rights Movement unfolded, ‘Dixie’ soon evoked a vision not of happy darkies on the plantation but of decidedly unhappy rednecks waving the Confederate flag and spewing contempt for national authority.”³⁵

Such an extended discourse on the evolution of the southern image may seem to be a sidebar to a discussion of reenactors. But it is critical to understand that the sharpening of the redneck stereotype and its pairing with the

Confederate flag and Confederate soldier happened rather quickly and at a critical time not only in the nation's history but also in the lives of most reenactors. Many of today's reenactors—including Don Worth and Vern Padgett—were drawn to the Civil War as children by an understanding of the South that was heroic and dramatic and that largely ignored issues of race. They are arguably the last generation of Americans who can legitimately claim to have embraced the Confederacy absent the racial overtones that are now associated with the southern soldier and battle flag. By contrast, Americans under the age of fifty, academics, political liberals, people of color, and Hollywood filmmakers are all overwhelmingly likely to be steeped in the negative understanding of the region and its symbols that emerged from the civil rights era. Consequently, Civil War reenactors are almost always presented in a negative fashion by outsiders—as embodying one or more elements of the modern southern redneck stereotype, particularly racism.

To start, scholars have generally been quite critical of reenactment. Elizabeth Young, a professor of English at Mount Holyoke, did one of the first scholarly analyses of reenactment. She reveals her suspicion that many reenactors are closeted homosexuals and asserts that “the collective impact of an admiring reanimation of the Confederacy is the renewal of racism.”³⁶ Similarly, historian Jim Cullen concedes that reenactments make him uneasy “because it is a way that white Americans assure themselves they have a past, too”; folklorist Tom Dunning describes the hobby as a pastime for “individuals threatened by a changing multi-cultural United States”; and sociologist Edward Sebesta asserts that “Confederate reenacting is a form of anti-government militia training.”³⁷ Sebesta is the coeditor of *Neo-Confederacy: A Critical Introduction* and is one of several scholars—Brian Britt and Lain Hart are others—who draw a connection between Civil War reenactment and the exceedingly reactionary, right-wing, neo-Confederate movement.³⁸

Documentarians who have examined reenactment are among the community's worst enemies. Particularly troublesome, from the reenactors' standpoint, is Glenn Kirschbaum's 2001 reenactment documentary *The Unfinished Civil War*, which aired repeatedly on the History Channel. The producers received extensive support from members of the reenactment community, including hundreds of hours of interviews. When the program finally aired, the reenactors were shocked and horrified to hear the narrator make liberal

use of terms such as “wild-eyed wackos” and “flag-waving racists.” Perhaps worst of all, the program featured lengthy clips of interviews with former Ku Klux Klan grand wizard David Duke, implying a relationship between reenactment and the KKK. “Now the public sees that and thinks (re-enactors are) the Ku Klux Klan in hiding,” complained Confederate reenactor Greg Walz.³⁹ “Every time that film airs it does more and more damage to our hobby,” lamented Union reenactor Paul Calloway. “It promotes the perception that we're all a bunch of wild-eyed wackos.”⁴⁰ “It was embarrassing,” opined Atlanta-based Confederate Mike Ventura. “A lot of our friends know this is our hobby but didn't know what we did. This portrayed us as a bunch of idiotic racists.”⁴¹ Many reenactors were so angry that they mounted a petition drive—unsuccessful—to have the program permanently removed from the History Channel's library.⁴²

The print media have also helped to stigmatize reenactors. Most notable is *Confederates in the Attic*, a 1998 best seller by former *New York Times* reporter Tony Horwitz. His book explores many different iterations of the Civil War as expressed in the modern-day South—from the exceedingly troublesome (an unapologetic white supremacist and anti-Semite named Walt) to the quaint (the *Gone with the Wind* museum and the oldest living Confederate widow).⁴³ One of the central characters of the book—he appears on the cover, in fact—is Robert Lee Hodge, a Confederate reenactor devoted to capturing the past as accurately as possible (usually through long, punishing marches with inadequate food and shelter). Although Horwitz makes it very clear that he is presenting a wide spectrum of beliefs, the juxtaposition of Hodge with people like Walt largely affirms the conception of Civil War reenactors as unredeemed racists. Consider, for example, these reader reviews posted on the website of bookseller Amazon.com:

Required reading for neo-Confederates and those who want to understand them. The material on the “hard-core” Civil War reenactor fringe is at once both fascinating and pathetic.

I have concluded that hardcore reenactors and others who worship the battle flag are suffering from an acute case of inferiority. Why don't white southerners take pride in the great writers from that region or music and folk art admired around the world? The first presidents were all Virginians, and half of the 13 original states were

southern. Why can't southerners take pride in these things instead of living up to the stereotypes of racism and ignorance imposed on them by others?

I personally know one of the men that Horwitz interviewed and commented about. Horwitz did a great disservice to this individual in completely misrepresenting him and his motives and activities in the hobby. Instead of presenting him as the calm, thoughtful, introspective individual I know him to be, Horwitz presented him as a rabid extremist.⁴⁴

Social activists, too, have weighed in against reenactment. Tim Wise, who advertises himself as an "antiracist essayist, author, and educator" and "one of the most brilliant, articulate and courageous critics of white privilege in the nation," decries reenactments as "racist bunk."⁴⁵ The NAACP has waded into the debate, expressing general opposition to reenactments across the country. This position received particular attention in 2003 when the Reverend James Piper, head of the NAACP's Beauregard-Vernon chapter, demanded that a planned reenactment in western Louisiana be canceled. He asserted that reenactments "disrupt harmony" and "disrupt social and civil peace" and explained that he would not "sit still for something that represents racism."⁴⁶

The entertainment media have been particularly effective at marginalizing reenactors as kooks and racists. To start, the list of modern crime dramas that have had at least one "reenactment episode" includes *CSI*, *Without a Trace*, *NCIS*, *The District*, *Psych*, and *Bones*.⁴⁷ Confederate reenactors make excellent suspects, especially when they are presented as social outcasts who are odd, maladjusted, and well armed. A pair of examples will suffice to illustrate the general tenor of these programs. In the *CSI* episode "Way to Go," Confederate reenactor Caleb Carson is a social pariah who wears a tight corset at all times to make his waist narrower and thus conform to nineteenth-century standards.⁴⁸ While attending a reenactment, he becomes enraged at a Union soldier who dares to use a cell phone during a battle and challenges him to a duel. Unbeknownst to the poor Union reenactor, Carson has live ammunition in his Civil War-era revolver. A misfire kills Caleb and saves the hapless Union infantryman's life.

In the *Without a Trace* episode "Cloudy with a Chance of Gettysburg," the viewer first sees a flashback of young Kirby Morris, who is humiliated by having

his pants torn off in front of his entire high school while receiving a prize for his historical essays. This causes him to become psychotic, and given his love of history, he gravitates toward Civil War reenactment. In the present, we learn that he is competing with a George Pickett impersonator for the affections of a young Confederate nurse. When "Pickett" turns up missing, Morris is the key suspect, although the ultimate culprit proves to be a Robert E. Lee impersonator. At the conclusion of the episode, the police detectives comment on the strangeness of the reenactment community. One remarks, "This [case] was an odd one," and the other agrees that it was "like being in a Salvador Dali painting."

While crime dramas tend to focus on the notion that reenactors—particularly Confederate reenactors—are maladjusted outcasts, comedies tend to emphasize that they are drunkards, fools, and bigots. The movie *Borat: Cultural Learnings of America for Make Benefit Glorious Nation of Kazakhstan* falls into this category, as do the television programs *Family Guy*, *30 Rock*, *South Park*, *The Simpsons*, *Everybody Loves Raymond*, *The Jeff Foxworthy Show*, *The Jeff Dunham Show*, *SpongeBob SquarePants*, and *Mr. Show*.⁴⁹ In *Borat*, the foreign-born title character attends a reenactment as a southerner, convincing his comrades in arms to pray that they will win the war or at least avoid being sodomized by the victorious Union armies. Consistent with the general approach of the movie, the purpose of the ruse is to cause discomfort and thus to hint at the reenactors' homophobia.

In the *Family Guy* episode "To Love and Die in Dixie," main characters Brian and Peter Griffin attend a Civil War reenactment where a drunken Ulysses S. Grant is knocked to the ground by Robert E. Lee. Lee declares a Confederate victory, and Peter objects, insisting that the North won the Civil War. A riot nearly ensues until Brian distracts the reenactors by shouting, "Hey, look over there! It's a newly married interracial gay couple burning the American flag!" In the *Jeff Dunham Show* episode "Civil War Games," a black puppet named Sweet Daddy Dee warns Confederate reenactors not to try to sell him into slavery. In the *SpongeBob SquarePants* episode "The Battle of Bikini Bottom"—yes, even children's cartoons have taken their potshots—reenactors fight a battle that will decide whether it is necessary to wash one's hands after using the bathroom. Naturally, the Confederates are the dirty, anti-hand-washing faction.

Generally speaking, these various groups of social elites—academics, documentarians, journalists, entertainers—have done a very effective job of stigmatizing Civil War reenactors. Recently, the news site CNN.com ran a

story on a Civil War reenactment that generated more than 600 responses. The comments included the following, and many others like them:

If it was up to these losers, slavery would still be legal and women wouldn't have rights. It's almost been 150 years since the war ended and yet they still fantasize about these "glory days." **BOTTOM LINE: YOU LOST!** Take that stupid flag down and actually try to help the nation PROGRESS, not REGRESS.

What's more redneck: Civil War Reenactments or NASCAR?

These people are scary. No doubt about it.

It is a redneck hobby. We should be grateful that they are providing these "history lessons" and not breeding.

It's still a redneck sport in my opinion. When you talk about honoring Confederates who fought and died for slavery, and wanting to mainly pretend to be the Confederate (the bad guy btw), then it's stupid. It's like reenacting the holocaust and wanting to be the Nazis. Granted I've never been to one, but based on what I read, including this article, there just seems to be no moral at these reenactments, no message on why the confederates lost the importance of the union prevailing.⁵⁰

Reenactors are predominantly white and considerably older and more conservative than the general populace. It is not unreasonable to suggest that their views on race lag a bit behind the prevailing opinion on, say, a college campus. And there are undoubtedly a handful of reenactors who would be more at home at a cross burning than a battle re-creation. But if we are to understand reenactment—or, more specifically, Confederate reenactment—primarily as an expression of white southern racism, we are left with a number of troublesome questions: What about the northerners and westerners who prefer the Confederacy? What about men like Don Worth, who were drawn to the Confederacy as children, well before they had an awareness of race? Do the thousands of foreign Confederate reenactors oppose a civil rights movement that took place in another country? What about the several hundred black men who reenact as Confederates—are they racists? Further, if the goal

is to advocate white supremacy, why not join an overtly white supremacist group like the Ku Klux Klan or the League of the South? Why bother with the hot wool uniforms and the antique weapons?

As we consider these questions, it is hard to avoid the conclusion that racism, by itself, is not a satisfactory explanation for the popularity of Confederate reenactment. To gain a better understanding of their motives, it seems reasonable to ask reenactors why they prefer the gray. A good starting place is Robert Lee Hodge, who explains:

My father is from Alabama and my mother's folks are from Tennessee, so even though I am from Ohio, I had a kinship with the South early on. Named after Lee and born on the same day as Jackson's birthday, I tend to lean the gray way. My folks were not rabid neo-Confeds, but my dad used to tease my mom for being a Yankee. . . .

For me it is easy to get wrapped up in the Confederacy; all I had to do was read. The other huge aspect is the visuals. To me, at least, my image of Johnnies looks more connected with the land—homespun, if you will. Civilian soldiers in often earth-colored uniforms, bedrolls, big slouch hats, bloused trousers, etc. fighting against the massive federal government soldiers in their dark blue (almost black) uniforms gives me the feeling of David fighting Goliath. The image of southern soldiers is attractive. As a child, I wanted to be a part of it.⁵¹

In other interviews conducted for this essay, I got similar answers dozens of times. For example, Duke Harless, who portrays a soldier from the Third Georgia Infantry, asks:

Is it because we can be more colorful and dashing as Confederates? Is it because if we do Union Infantry we are limited in dress to dark blue coat, light blue pants, and a kepi? Is not a trusty Springfield musket enough? Do we have to have sabers, pistols, and shotguns? Do we just like being underdogs, defying the "oppressive government"? Are we worried about our great-great-granddaddy doing monkey flips in his grave if we wore Union blue? Maybe the Union coat of blue and the trappings of an infantryman don't seem to have as much panache as the gaudy vests, feather and animal-part hats, and the arsenal hanging from the belts of a Reb cavalryman.⁵²

John Quimby, who does both Rebel and Union impressions, ties the appeal of the Confederate soldier even more explicitly to the Lost Cause interpretation of the war: "We've all consumed the tales of the desperate southern warrior, down to his last patched pair of trousers and barefoot in the mud. This symbolic image was promoted in the postwar era—a time when southerners were struggling with their own self-image. The barefoot Rebel is a heroic icon of the Lost Cause."⁵³

As already noted, the Lost Cause interpretation of the war blends heroic storybook elements (e.g., the gallant Robert E. Lee) with a political message (e.g., the insignificance of slavery). Virtually all Confederate reenactors—and most Federals, too—embrace the heroic part of the Lost Cause (recall, for example, Don Worth's childhood fascination with John Singleton Mosby). This is the single most important factor behind the appeal of the Confederacy and the southern soldier. In addition, some Confederate reenactors perceive a parallel between the Reconstruction-era South and today's South. That is, they believe the South needs to be "redeemed" again—not in terms of white political control but in terms of Americans' perception of the region. It is primarily this group of reenactors—Vern Padgett among them—that has revived the political dimension of the Lost Cause interpretation after it lay dormant for more than half a century.

Historian Alan Nolan has identified a number of common motifs in the writings of the Lost Cause. An examination of the most important of these motifs and their place in the reenactment community illustrates the extent to which most reenactors tend to retain the heroic elements of the interpretation, while the political elements find a narrower, though still palpable, expression.⁵⁴

Heroic Motif: Lee and Jackson

Robert E. Lee and Stonewall Jackson are the great heroic figures of the Lost Cause, along with a handful of other Confederates—J. E. B. Stuart, George Pickett, and Nathan Bedford Forrest. The Lost Cause also has its villains; most prominent is Confederate general James Longstreet (who is blamed for the defeat at Gettysburg and committed the sin of becoming a Republican after the war), along with the men who led the North to victory: Ulysses S. Grant and William T. Sherman.

The preeminence of Lee and Jackson is not evident at the reenactments

themselves. Portraying specific individuals, particularly high-ranking officers, is not common, so one generally finds a Lee or a Jackson only at very large reenactments of battles at which they were actually present. However, their popularity among reenactors is evident in other ways. The *Camp Chase Gazette*, which styles itself the "voice of Civil War reenacting," has a broader reach than any other reenactment publication.⁵⁵ Its editors try to provide balanced coverage, but they must also cater to their subscribers. Further, they have little control over the content that is not generated by the magazine's staff—this includes letters to the editor, advertisements, and the "Observation Post," a collection of news items and announcements provided entirely by readers.

An examination of the content of the *Camp Chase Gazette* over the past fifteen years (1998–2012) speaks to the predominance of Lost Cause heroes in the reenactment community.⁵⁶ Robert E. Lee was the subject of an article, announcement, letter, or advertisement sixty-seven times in that span, or roughly once every other issue. That number is quite high, given that the magazine's advertisements tend to focus on battle reenactments rather than specific individuals (in contrast to other publications, such as the *Civil War Times Illustrated*, which showcase a lot of Confederate-themed artwork).⁵⁷ After Lee, four of the six next most commonly mentioned figures were Lost Cause heroes of various sorts, with only Abraham Lincoln and George Armstrong Custer (a dashing figure in the Lost Cause mold) breaking up the southern monopoly. Ulysses S. Grant ranked ninth, and other important Union generals were lucky if their names appeared in the pages of the magazine once a year. Hapless George Gordon Meade, the triumphant commander at Gettysburg, was *never* mentioned in that fifteen-year span, which is particularly interesting, given the popularity of that battle.

The esteem in which Lee and Jackson are held also comes through in the interviews conducted for this essay. More than 30 percent of reenactors identified either Lee or Jackson as the Civil War figure they admired most. The sentiments of reenactor Mark Silber are representative: "I am a northerner by birth and residence, but I admire Robert E. Lee as one of the greatest and finest Americans to walk on this earth. He is a man of honor, courage, and duty. Robert E. Lee has earned the love of millions of his fellow southerners and other Americans over the decades."⁵⁸ Other Lost Cause heroes, including Stuart (cited by 8 percent of interviewees) and Pickett (6 percent), are also more widely admired than northerners Grant (5 percent) and Sherman (4 percent) and the unfortunate Longstreet (1 percent).

Heroic Motif: The Preeminence of Virginia

An adjunct to the veneration of Lee and Jackson is the Lost Cause ideology's focus on the military theater of Virginia and the two armies that fought there: the Army of Northern Virginia and the Army of the Potomac. To use a term employed by historian Gary Gallagher, Lost Cause writers present Virginia as the "cockpit" of the Civil War.⁵⁹ They claim that Richmond was always the main focus of the Union army and that the most significant fighting occurred around the Confederate capital. This area, of course, was where Lee and Jackson scored all their dramatic victories.

There are several ways in which the preeminence of the Virginia theater is reflected in reenactment. The first is the location of each year's grand anniversary reenactment. The Civil War was four years long, so in four out of every five years, there is an "important" anniversary—one divisible by five—for an entire year's worth of Civil War battles. For example, 2012 was the 150th anniversary of the battles fought in 1862—Second Bull Run, Antietam, Fort Donelson, Shiloh, and Murfreesboro, among others. In each of these anniversary years, one reenactment gets the broadest attention and the highest attendance. And invariably, that reenactment is a re-creation of a battle between the Army of the Potomac and the Army of Northern Virginia. For 1861 (1996, 2001, 2006, 2011), the grand reenactment was First Bull Run; for 1862 (1997, 2002, 2007, 2012), Antietam; for 1863 (1998, 2003, 2008, 2013), Gettysburg; and for 1864 (1999, 2004, 2009, 2014), the Wilderness. For each of these years, there are alternative non-Virginia options that might be more justifiable in terms of importance to the Civil War—Fort Sumter for 1861, Shiloh for 1862, Vicksburg for 1863, and Atlanta for 1864. Some dedicated reenactors gamely attempt to stage events at these locations, but the Virginia battles invariably draw many more attendees.⁶⁰

The centrality of Virginia is also reflected in reenactors' choice of units to portray. Of the 3.4 million men who fought in the Civil War, roughly 600,000 (17 percent) served in one of the armies in the Virginia theater for at least part of the war.⁶¹ Of the 211 reenactment groups that are currently active, 137 (nearly 65 percent) portray units that were part of either the Army of Northern Virginia or the Army of the Potomac. In other words, the average reenactor is four times more likely to be in one of the great armies of the Virginia theater than was the average Civil War soldier.

Finally, items appearing in the pages of the *Camp Chase Gazette* also

speak to the prominence of the Virginia theater. Based on the number of mentions in the magazine between 1998 and 2012, the two main Virginia armies—Army of Northern Virginia and Army of the Potomac—ranked first and third, with the Army of Northern Virginia far and away the most popular. The Army of Tennessee, though not the "cockpit" of the war, also has an honored place in Lost Cause mythology and served as the home base for Nathan Bedford Forrest and his exploits; it ranked second in terms of mentions in the *Camp Chase Gazette*. The most important Union armies after the Army of the Potomac—including the Army of the Tennessee, which Grant commanded for the better part of two years, as well as the Armies of the Cumberland, Ohio, James, Mississippi, Shenandoah, and Gulf—combined for forty-three mentions over the past fifteen years, fewer than the Army of Northern Virginia by itself (mentioned fifty times).

Civil War battles tell a similar story. Gettysburg, though a southern defeat, is the central battle of the Lost Cause mythology. It is the "high-water mark," the moment when the Confederacy ostensibly came closest to victory, according to postwar southern thinking. It has found its way into the pages of the *Camp Chase Gazette* 295 times in the last fifteen years, or nearly two times per issue. This is more than the next two most popular battles combined. The second entry on the list—the Bull Runs (which are often discussed in combination in the magazine and so are combined here)—is also a Lost Cause favorite. From there, the list is less obviously skewed in favor of Lost Cause battles—Chickamauga, Shiloh, Vicksburg, and Chattanooga were all in the West, while Chancellorsville, a key Lost Cause battle, ranks rather low. These anomalies can be explained by two factors: first, there is a small but die-hard contingent of reenactors that tries each year to use the pages of the *Gazette* to rally support for western reenactments (without success, as noted earlier); second, large reenactments of Chancellorsville are rare, for a pair of reasons. Most important, the anniversary of that battle (May 1863) is only two months before that of Gettysburg (July 1863). Any reenactor who is interested in spending the time and money to travel to a large-scale reenactment is going to wait for Gettysburg. Less significant is that Chancellorsville's role in Lost Cause mythology has more to do with what happened after the battle—the accidental shooting and death of Stonewall Jackson—and less to do with the battle itself (though it was unquestionably a great victory for the Confederacy).

Heroic Motif: The Idealized Confederate Soldier

The Lost Cause interpretation also has a central place of honor for the common soldier of the Confederacy. He was, as Nolan explains, portrayed as "heroic, indefatigable, gallant, and law-abiding."⁶² It is not difficult to find similar sentiments among reenactors. When asked why he chooses to reenact a southerner, David Upton of the Third Tennessee says: "I think of Confederate soldiers as being a bit more admirable than their Union counterparts. First of all, their sacrifice was greater, given the suffering that they had to endure due to lack of food, supplies, and so forth. Second, they were fighting to protect their homes, and I can identify with that."⁶³ An Ohio reenactor echoes these sentiments: "A rebel has got that stigma to it, you're the outcast, you're the black sheep. Kind of like the dark side!"⁶⁴

There is another, more subtle way in which the idealized notion of the Confederate soldier is evident in Civil War reenactment. A common perception in the reenactment community is that men who portray Confederates are more likely to be blue collar than their Union counterparts. Joseph Bolivar of the Ninth New York observes: "The people who [are] middle class will have a tendency to join a Union group. This may show in the education profile as to the amount of education one has as to which side he joins. . . . I would say Union reenactors have a higher income than Confederate soldiers."⁶⁵ David Pleger of the Second Vermont shares this perception: "Confederate reenactors are more likely to be truck drivers or construction workers. Union reenactors are more likely to be doctors, lawyers, or teachers."⁶⁶ What is interesting about this widely held perception is that it is false. Among the individuals interviewed for this essay, there were dozens of Confederates in white-collar professions and dozens of Federals in blue-collar professions. In a study of income patterns among reenactors, Mark L. Shanks found no particular disparity between the two groups. The average income of the 380 Confederates he surveyed was \$61,900; for the 349 Union reenactors that responded, the average income was \$63,800. In other words, the average Confederate reenactor and the average Union reenactor are both comfortably middle class.⁶⁷

Lost Cause authors always portray the experience of southern soldiers as vastly more challenging than that of Union soldiers. Due to shortages of men and materials, Confederate soldiers were regularly forced to march and fight hard, often without adequate food or supplies. Meanwhile, Union soldiers

were thought to have a much more comfortable existence due to their overwhelmingly superior numbers and almost endless amounts of food and supplies. To some extent, these perceptions are based in truth, but there were many cases in which Confederate soldiers were well supplied and Union soldiers were forced to fight with less than adequate provisions. In any case, it seems reasonable to suggest that the Lost Cause's presentation of Confederates as hardworking, hard-marching, ragtag military men has translated into the perception that Confederate reenactors are also ragtag blue-collar types.

Political Motif: Slavery

The most important political issue addressed by the Lost Cause, at least for modern Americans, is southern slavery and its role in provoking the Civil War. The Lost Cause writers, for their part, have advanced a number of assertions about slavery: that the South did not go to war to protect its "peculiar institution," that slavery would have disappeared eventually, and that the slaves were generally happy with their lot in life.

There are, broadly speaking, three different approaches to the issue of slavery on display in the reenactment community. The first is to confront the issue head-on. Don Worth, for example, says: "As with most wars, what the individuals thought they were fighting for didn't have much to do with what STARTED the war—it was the politicians that started the war. And their beef was over representation in congress (and with the election of a President who the south felt would not be sympathetic to their interests). The defining characteristic of that representation was whether a state was slave or free. To me, that makes the war (primarily) about slavery."⁶⁸ According to Greg Romanek, who does both Confederate and Union impressions, "A reenactor who does not understand the effects of race and slavery on that time period is not coming to grips with one of, if not the most important, factors which resulted in the carnage of 1861–65."⁶⁹ Confederate reenactor Levi Miller puts things even more succinctly: "I'm real glad that I was born into the US of A where racial equality is actively promoted, and where on weekends I can freely play the role of a nineteenth century armed secessionist."⁷⁰

A second approach to slavery—the most common one in the reenactment community—is to downplay the importance of the issue. This is, presumably, the most effective way to make the Civil War a "usable past." Approximately 50 percent of reenactors argue that the Civil War was caused

by an issue or issues other than slavery.⁷¹ The "peculiar institution" is rarely presented at reenactments, as it tends to be uncomfortable for both those playing the role and those witnessing the performance. The *Camp Chase Gazette* has referenced slavery only twenty-six times in the past fifteen years.

The third approach to slavery is the "black Confederate" argument. It is presumably a sign of progress that the myth of "happy slaves," portrayed in movies and books before the 1960s, is dead. Not even the most die-hard Confederate reenactor would argue this position today. Only slightly better, though just as ahistorical, is the notion that Vern Padgett advocates: that tens of thousands or hundreds of thousands of slaves took up arms for the Confederacy. The implication is obvious: if slaves were willing to fight for the Confederacy, then their lives were not so bad and their masters were not as evil or wrongheaded as they might seem. While it is unquestionably offensive to downplay the horrors of slavery, it is worth noting that the primary goals of this argument are not racist in nature—that is, the purpose is not to assert white supremacy or black inferiority but to express disdain for academic elites and their views on the war and to apologize for and "redeem" the South.

Indeed, whatever their position on the question of slavery—which is, after all, a nineteenth-century issue—reenactors are all but unanimous in their abhorrence of racism. Because they know that the media and the general public are suspicious of their hobby, they usually show great sensitivity to this issue, even the Vern Padgetts of the world. Though it tends to avoid the touchy subject of slavery, the *Camp Chase Gazette* regularly tackles racial issues. For example, a 2001 article entitled "Racism: An Issue for Living Historians" exhorts reenactors to remember that perspectives on race have changed in the last 140 years and asks them to be careful not to incorporate the attitudes and language of the past into their impressions.⁷²

Confederate reenactors tend to be particularly careful when it comes to this issue. For example, Temple University history professor and Union reenactor Gregory Urwin served as a consultant on a short film. In one scene, three Confederate reenactors were asked to use a rather serious racial slur. Regardless of how much the director pleaded, they simply would not use the word, which eventually had to be looped in during postproduction.⁷³ There are also a number of stories of Confederate reenactors publicly confronting racists at reenactment events. For example, at a September 2006 reenactment in Gettysburg, twenty Klansmen made an appearance. The first group to

stand in their way and to insist that they take their Confederate flags and leave was the Thirty-Seventh Texas Infantry.⁷⁴

Beyond dramatic incidents such as these, Confederate reenactors commonly issue careful disclaimers about their racial predilections whenever they feel it is necessary. This one appears in Jonah Begone's article "Advancing the Southern Cause": "The traditional Southern point of view . . . is one of political and social conservatism. I am for a restrained federal government, more political power given to the states, Second Amendment rights (good luck reenacting without them), an awareness and respect for heritage . . . and the maintenance of the usual social customs and traditions. Racism, obviously, is not one of the customs I would endorse."⁷⁵ Nearly every southern reenactment group that has a website includes a similar disclaimer. For example, www.9thvirginia.com advises visitors and recruits: "We portray a Confederate cavalry regiment as it would have looked in 1863. We are not a 'reb' unit, we do not tolerate extremists or racism." Likewise, www.texas-brigade.org announces that the unit's members "denounce racism, racial supremacists, hate groups and other groups or individuals that misuse or desecrate the symbols of the United States of America and/or the former Confederate States of America; and [it] has no modern political agenda or status."

Similarly, as the Sons of Confederate Veterans (SCV) and other organizations have grown more friendly to white supremacy in the last decade, many members of the reenactment community have urged them to change their ways or, failing that, for reenactors to separate from such groups. Confederate reenactor Walter C. Hilderman III, who hosts a website dedicated to this issue, writes:

[If] SCV reenactors bring their in-your-face attitudes and new found political activism into the hobby, Confederate reenacting will come to be viewed by the public, liberal activists and the authorities with the same suspicion that the entire SCV has generated in recent years. . . . Civil War reenacting has become a popular American teaching and learning experience, complete with big budgets, vendors, permits, first responders, and inevitably, insurance policies. Reenactments, large and small, require public acceptance and support. Without the public's trust in our reasons for being Confederate reenactors, our hobby and our mission of teaching American history through reenacting will end.⁷⁶

And finally, to give Robert Lee Hodge the last word on the issue: "I don't give a shit if my sister marries a black guy. Unless he's a farb."⁷⁷

The above discussion illustrates two important points. The first is the enduring power of the Lost Cause, a 150-year-old interpretation of the Civil War that still has enough salience to resonate with Americans, particularly those who grew up prior to the 1960s. There is no question that the Lost Cause is a better explanation of the enduring popularity of the Confederate soldier than is the notion that Confederate reenactment is a socially acceptable way to express racist sentiments.

The second point is that we must be careful about painting groups such as Civil War reenactors—what W. James Booth has called "communities of memory"—with too broad a brush.⁷⁸ There is no reason to assume that all members of a group this large have the same or even similar viewpoints. There are substantive differences between Don Worth and Vern Padgett, and if the label "racist" is to be applied—which is a matter of opinion—it is far more apropos for the latter than the former. Of particular concern is the tendency for some observers to deploy the term *neo-Confederate* in discussing Confederate reenactment. The Southern Poverty Law Center is the foremost authority on white supremacist groups in the United States, and it offers this definition:

The term neo-Confederacy is used to describe twentieth and twenty-first century revivals of pro-Confederate sentiment in the United States. Strongly nativist and advocating measures to end immigration, neo-Confederacy claims to pursue Christianity and heritage and other supposedly fundamental values that modern Americans are seen to have abandoned.

Neo-Confederacy also incorporates advocacy of traditional gender roles, is hostile towards democracy, strongly opposes homosexuality, and exhibits an understanding of race that favors segregation and suggests white supremacy. In many cases, neo-Confederates are openly secessionist.⁷⁹

There is simply no evidence for the existence of these views among the vast majority of Confederate reenactors, and to argue or imply otherwise is a gross distortion.

In addition to these two points, this essay suggests an obvious question:

Should the Confederacy and its symbols still be automatically associated with racism? As long as the Confederate flag and the Confederate soldier come under attack, the Vern Padgetts of the world will continue to dig in their heels and will undoubtedly continue to embrace and promote ahistorical understandings of the Civil War. Historian Peter S. Carmichael, in an essay penned in 2011, observes, "The extreme categorizing behind this discourse has created impenetrable walls between those on both sides who, in their separate worlds, demonize the other without having to engage in meaningful dialogue."⁸⁰ It is hard to argue that maintaining such a wall—between North and South, white and black, liberal and conservative, academic and popular historians—is productive.

This question was also raised at a September 2012 panel on the preliminary Emancipation Proclamation. It was fielded by historian Christy Coleman, who is African American and must address three different constituencies—northerners, southerners, and African Americans—as director of the American Civil War Center at Richmond's Tredgar Iron Works. Her answer may point the way forward on this issue:

So my point is, when it comes to the Confederate, the Confederate heritage person, . . . you will often see, especially if you drive—the further south you drive—occasionally you'll see the little bumper stickers that say heritage, not hate. For those individuals that's exactly what it is, they're just honoring what their ancestors thought was right. And for me, as an African-American woman who grew up in Virginia hearing all this foolishness, to me it is, okay, I'm willing to acknowledge that, but please don't dismiss the role and the function of our folks.⁸¹

Very well put.

Notes

The title of this essay is from a post-Civil War song that expresses the iconoclasm of many southerners in the late nineteenth century. The entire first verse reads: Oh, I'm a good ol' rebel, yes, that's just what I am / And for this, their "land of freedom," I do not care a damn! / I'm proud I fought against 'em; I only wish we'd won, / And I don't want their pardon for anything I done!

1. E-mails by Vern Padgett, May 2, 2001, August 23, 2002, and July 5, 2001.
2. The "black Confederate" argument has become popular among some southern partisans in the last fifteen to twenty years and has been the subject of a number of books and articles. See, for example, Charles Barrow Kelly, J. H. Segars, and R. B. Rosenberg, eds., *Black Confederates* (Gretna, La.: Pelican Publishing, 2001), and Arthur W. Bergeron et al., *Black Southerners in Gray* (Redondo Beach, Calif.: Rank and File Publications, 1997).
3. I personally witnessed Padgett's lecture at the San Gabriel Civil War Round Table on July 14, 2002.
4. From Worth's personal homepage, <http://worth.bol.ucla.edu/> (accessed November 26, 2012).
5. Interview with Don Worth, July 4, 2008.
6. Ibid.
7. Because there are no central organizations with which reenactors register, it is difficult to estimate these numbers accurately. This number is based on interviews done for this essay, articles submitted to *Camp Chase Gazette*, and membership rolls from several local organizations around the country.
8. Not surprisingly, many of these African American units portray the Fifty-Fourth Massachusetts Infantry Regiment, the subject of the film *Glory*.
9. The size of the Confederate and Union armies is reported differently in different sources. The *Official Records* puts the size of the Union army at nearly 3 million, but this number is not reliable because it does not account for soldiers who enlisted more than once. Most other sources give numbers within 100,000 of those presented here.
10. In desperation, due to severe manpower shortages and a crumbling war effort, the South finally made arrangements to begin conscripting slaves in December 1864. However, before these units could be assembled and trained, the war came to a close.
11. There are a few exceptions, most notably the reenacted Thirty-Seventh Texas, which is made up almost exclusively of African Americans.
12. James O. Farmer, "Playing Rebels: Reenactment as Nostalgia and Defense of the Confederacy in the Battle of Aiken," *Southern Cultures* 11, no. 1 (Spring 2005): 71–72.
13. Tara McPherson, *Reconstructing Dixie: Race, Gender, and Nostalgia in the Imagined South* (Durham, N.C.: Duke University Press Books, 2003), xiii. Other key books on this subject include Jack Temple Kirby, *Media-Made Dixie: The South in the American Imagination* (Athens: University of Georgia Press, 1986); Peter Applebome, *Dixie Rising* (New York: Times Books, 1996); and Rebecca Bridges Watts, *Contemporary Southern Identity: Community through Controversy* (Jackson: University Press of Mississippi, 2008).

14. For an overview of the Lost Cause, see Gary W. Gallagher, *Lee and His Generals in War and Memory* (Baton Rouge: Louisiana State University Press, 1998); Thomas L. Connelly and Barbara Bellows, *God and General Longstreet: The Lost Cause and the Southern Mind* (Baton Rouge: Louisiana State University Press, 1982); Gaines M. Foster, *Ghosts of the Confederacy: Defeat, the Lost Cause, and the Emergence of the New South* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1987); and Gary Gallagher and Alan T. Nolan, *The Myth of the Lost Cause and Civil War History* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 2000).

15. See Karen L. Cox, *Dreaming of Dixie: How the South Was Created in American Popular Culture* (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 2011); Nina Silber, *The Romance of Reunion: Northerners and the South, 1865–1900* (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 1993); and Robert H. Wiebe, *The Search for Order, 1877–1920* (New York: Hill and Wang, 1966).

16. McPherson, *Reconstructing Dixie*, 3.

17. Foster, *Ghosts of the Confederacy*, 3–8.

18. For an extended discussion of this subject, see Anthony J. Stanonis, ed., *Dixie Emporium: Tourism, Foodways, and Consumer Culture in the American South* (Athens: University of Georgia Press, 2008), and Grace Elizabeth Hale, *Making Whiteness: The Culture of Segregation in the South, 1890–1940* (New York: Pantheon, 1998).

19. There are relatively few overviews of the South's portrayal in popular music, as most studies focus on specific eras or genres. The best available general treatment is Mark Kemp, *Dixie Lullaby: A Story of Music, Race, and New Beginnings in a New South* (New York: Free Press, 2004).

20. The portrayal of the South in film has received extensive attention. See Karl G. Heidler, ed., *Images of the South: Constructing a Regional Culture on Film and Video* (Athens: University of Georgia Press, 1993); Warren French, ed., *The South and Film* (Jackson: University Press of Mississippi, 1981); Deborah E. Barker and Kathryn McKee, eds., *American Cinema and the Southern Imaginary* (Athens: University of Georgia Press, 2011); Allison Graham, *Framing the South: Hollywood, Television, and Race during the Civil Rights Struggle* (Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press, 2001); and Bruce Chadwick, *The Reel Civil War: Mythmaking in American Film* (New York: Vintage Books, 2002).

21. Examples with a decidedly Lost Cause influence include Douglass Southall Freeman, *R. E. Lee, A Biography* (New York: Scribner, 1934–1935); Ulrich B. Phillips, *American Negro Slavery: A Survey of the Supply, Employment and Control of Negro Labor as Determined by the Plantation Regime* (Baton Rouge: Louisiana State University Press, 1918); Shelby Foote, *Civil War: A Narrative* (New York: Random House, 1958–1974); and Bruce Catton, *The American Heritage Picture History of the Civil War* (New York: American Heritage, 1960). Foote and Catton are both critical of

some elements of Lost Cause thinking but thoroughly embrace others, particularly those that mesh well with their taste for dramatic narrative.

22. For a discussion of this point, see Mark Royden Winchell, *Reinventing the South: Versions of a Literary Region* (Columbia: University of Missouri Press, 2006).

23. Henry Cavendish, "Bigotry and Ignorance in Deep South," *Chicago Daily Tribune*, July 22, 1951, 114.

24. Alexander Holmes, "Another Side of Segregation in the South," *Los Angeles Times*, January 9, 1956, A5.

25. Robert E. Baker, "Shame Abating Arkansas Fever: Little Rock Feeling a Nation's Disgust," *Washington Post*, September 15, 1957, E3.

26. Harnett T. Kane, "Change in the Mardi Gras Spirit," *New York Times*, January 29, 1961, SM10; Saunders Redding, "The South and Society," *New York Times*, October 31, 1965, BR88.

27. George Gallup, "How North, South View Each Other," *Los Angeles Times*, May 27, 1957, 30.

28. See John Shelton Reed, *The Enduring South: Subcultural Persistence in Mass Society* (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 1972), 25.

29. Disney went so far as to repudiate *The Song of the South*, and the film is still not available for purchase in the United States.

30. The dramatic change in filmic portrayals of the South is discussed in, among other books, Scott Von Doviak, *Hick Flicks: The Rise and Fall of Redneck Cinema* (Jefferson, N.C.: McFarland, 2005), and Andrew B. Leiter, ed., *Southerners on Film: Essays on Hollywood Portrayals since the 1970s* (Jefferson, N.C.: McFarland, 2011).

31. See John Shelton Reed, *Surveying the South: Studies in Regional Sociology* (Columbia: University of Missouri Press, 1993), 51–65.

32. The word *redneck* first appeared in print in the 1830s and was used to denigrate the missionary efforts of the Presbyterian Church, which tried to appeal to working-class whites that other denominations deemed unworthy.

33. For a discussion of the "declension" of the redneck stereotype, see James C. Cobb, *Away Down South: A History of Southern Identity* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2005), and Jim Goad, *The Redneck Manifesto: How Hillbillies, Hicks, and White Trash Became America's Scapegoats* (New York: Simon and Schuster, 1998).

34. "The Various Shady Lives of the Ku Klux Klan," *Time*, April 9, 1965, 24–25.

35. Cobb, *Away Down South*, 1.

36. Elizabeth Young, *Disarming the Nation: Women's Writing and the American Civil War* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1999), 293.

37. Jim Cullen, *The Civil War in Popular Culture: A Reusable Past* (Washington, D.C.: Smithsonian Institution, 1995), 199; Tom Dunning, "Civil War Reenactments: Performance as a Cultural Practice," *Australasian Journal of American Studies*

21, no. 1 (July 2002): 64; *Anti-Neo Confederate Blog*, <http://newtknight.blogspot.com/2007/06/confederate-reenacting-gets-ugly.html> (accessed December 2, 2012).

38. Lain Hart, "Authentic Recreation: Living History and Leisure," *Museum and Society* 5, no. 2 (July 2007); Brian Britt, "Neo-Confederate Culture," *Z Magazine* 9, no. 12 (December 1996).

39. Lauren Fagan, "Re-enactors Rip TV Flag Documentary; History Drives Them, Not Political Agenda," *South Bend Tribune*, March 15, 2001, A1.

40. Jeffery Scott, "History Channel Film Draws Ire of Reenactors," *Atlanta Journal-Constitution*, March 13, 2001, 2C.

41. David Bauder, "Civil War Re-enactors Push for Boycott; The History Channel: Many Believe that the Network Is Portraying Them as Racists," *Telegraph Herald*, March 17, 2001, A8.

42. Civil War News online, http://www.civilwarnews.com/archive/articles/history_channel.htm (accessed December 2, 2012).

43. Tony Horwitz, *Confederates in the Attic: Dispatches from the Unfinished Civil War* (New York: Pantheon Books, 1998), 81–86, 282–311, 336–51.

44. Amazon.com customer reviews for *Confederates in the Attic*, <http://www.amazon.com/Confederates-Attic-Dispatches-Unfinished-Civil/product-reviews/067975833X> (accessed December 2, 2012).

45. Tim Wise, <http://www.timwise.org/2010/09/south-carolina-republicans-show-their-racist-asses-again-this-is-a-historical-constant-actually/> (accessed December 2, 2012).

46. Associated Press, February 16, 2003.

47. Episodes "Way to Go," *CSI*; "Cloudy with a Chance of Gettysburg," *Without a Trace*; "Silver War," *NCIS*; "A House Divided," *The District*; "Weekend Warriors," *Psych*; and "The Dentist in the Ditch," *Bones*.

48. Apparently, there was something of a historical misunderstanding among the show's writing staff: narrow waists were desirable for nineteenth-century women, not men.

49. Episodes "To Love and Die in Dixie," *Family Guy*; "When It Rains It Pours," *30 Rock*; "The Red Badge of Gayness," *South Park*; "The Sweetest Apu," *The Simpsons*; "Civil War," *Everybody Loves Raymond*; "Foxworthy Shall Rise Again," *The Jeff Foxworthy Show*; "Civil War Games," *The Jeff Dunham Show*; "The Battle of Bikini Bottom," *SpongeBob SquarePants*; and "Like Chickens . . . Delicious Chickens," *Mr. Show*.

50. "'Living History' on Civil War Battlefields," <http://www.cnn.com/2011/LIVING/04/09/civil.war.reenacting/index.html> (accessed December 2, 2012). Reader comments are presented unedited.

51. Interview with Robert Lee Hodge, October 25, 2006.

52. Interview with Duke Harless, April 20, 2001.

53. Interview with John Quimby, May 2, 2001.
54. Alan T. Nolan, "The Anatomy of the Myth," in Gallagher and Nolan, *Myth of the Lost Cause*, 11–34.
55. The *Camp Chase Gazette* was first founded as a unit newsletter by William Keitz in 1971. It expanded its circulation dramatically in the 1980s and now sells approximately 8,000 copies a month.
56. The magazine is published ten times per year, so fifteen years equates to 150 issues.
57. The portrayal of the Confederacy in popular magazines, particularly in artwork, is addressed in Gary Gallagher, *Causes Won, Lost, and Forgotten: How Hollywood and Popular Art Shape What We Know about the Civil War* (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 2008).
58. Interview with Mark Silber, November 11, 2012.
59. Gary W. Gallagher, "Jubal A. Early, the Lost Cause, and Civil War History: A Persistent Legacy," in Gallagher and Nolan, *Myth of the Lost Cause*, 35–59.
60. To take one example, the Gettysburg reenactment of 1998 drew 30,000 participants, while the Vicksburg reenactment on the same days drew 4,000.
61. These numbers are even more difficult to assess than the overall troop strength of the two armies because many units were transferred into and out of them. Nonetheless, this estimate was affirmed by noted expert Robert Krick.
62. Nolan, "Anatomy of the Myth," 17.
63. Interview with David Upton, January 11, 1999.
64. Quoted in Gordon L. Jones, "Gut History: Civil War Reenacting and the Making of an American Past" (PhD diss., Emory University, 2007), 338.
65. Quoted in Mark L. Shanks, "Who Wears the Blue and Grey? A Survey of Civil War Reenactors" (unpublished paper).
66. Interview with David Pleger, February 12, 1999.
67. Shanks, "Who Wears the Blue and Grey?"
68. E-mail from Don Worth to the author, May 2, 2001.
69. Greg Romanek, *A Civil War Reenactor's Guidebook: Tips and Suggestions from the Field* (Berwyn Heights, Md.: Heritage Books, 2009), 30.
70. Levi Miller, "Letters to the Editor," *Camp Chase Gazette* 22, no. 10 (December 2005): 4.
71. Jones, "Gut History," 334.
72. Greg M. Romanek, "Racism: An Issue for Living Historians," *Camp Chase Gazette* 18, no. 7 (October 2001): 50–51.
73. Interview with Gregory Urwin, September 6, 2004.
74. For a thorough narrative of the incident, see "Protesting the Klan at Gettysburg," <http://www.bivouacbooks.com/bbv5i3s2.htm> (accessed December 2, 2012).
75. Jonah Begone, "Advancing the Southern Cause," *Camp Chase Gazette* 17, no. 7 (October 2000): 56–57.
76. Save the SCV homepage, <http://www.savethescv.org/> (accessed December 2, 2012).
77. Quoted in Horwitz, *Confederates in the Attic*, 246. *Farb* is reenactor slang for "phony."
78. W. James Booth, *Communities of Memory: On Witness, Identity, and Justice* (Ithaca, N.Y.: Cornell University Press, 2006), 3.
79. Southern Poverty Law Center, <http://www.splcenter.org/get-informed/intelligence-files/ideology/neo-confederate> (accessed December 2, 2012).
80. Peter S. Carmichael, "Truth Is Mighty & Will Eventually Prevail: Political Correctness, Neo-Confederates, and Robert E. Lee," *Southern Cultures* 17, no. 3 (Fall 2011): 6–27.
81. "Should We Still Associate Racism with Southern Heritage?" <http://www.c-spanvideo.org/clip/4091984> (accessed December 2, 2012).